

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Data Analytics and Business Intelligence English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For data analysts, BI developers, analytics engineers, data scientists, reporting teams, business analysts, and data-driven managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Metric Definitions and Business Questions

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Data Quality and Trust

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

03 Dashboards and Executive Reporting

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

04 Causation, Correlation, and Caveats

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 SQL, Models, and Transformation Logic

Clarify missing information before responding.

06 Experiment Readouts and Statistical Thinking

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

07 Data Governance and Privacy

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

08 Insight Storytelling and Recommendations

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Metric Definitions and Business Questions

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

Two teams report different active-user totals. One counts logins; the other counts completed transactions.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: metric, business definition, source of truth, owner.

Model response

What action qualifies a user as active, and over what period? The two totals use different definitions. Let's agree on the business question and label each measure clearly.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Active by login or completed transaction? - Fictional metric discussion using the lesson case: two teams report different active-user totals because one counts logins and the other completed transactions.
2. An order placed is not an order fulfilled - Fictional operations reporting: sales counts orders placed, while fulfillment counts orders shipped; both reports use the label orders this week.
3. Revenue before or after refunds? - Fictional reporting clarification: two internal summaries use revenue but one subtracts refunds; tax treatment and reporting period are unspecified.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Does a reopened ticket count again?

A fictional service dashboard reports tickets resolved this month. The brief does not say whether a ticket resolved twice after reopening counts once or twice. The support manager needs a workload measure. Clarify the event and counting unit.

Role A: BI analyst: ask whether the question concerns unique tickets or resolution actions.

Role B: Support manager: explain the workload purpose and identify the definition owner.

Possible opening: For workload, do you want unique tickets or each resolution action, including work after reopening?

Success checks

- Distinguish objects from repeated events.
- Connect the definition to the business question.
- Agree a precise label and owner review.

Add a complication: The manager asks to keep the same label for both measures.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Data Quality and Trust

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A dashboard refreshed today, but one source table contains data only through Monday. A manager assumes all figures are current.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: data quality, freshness, completeness, pipeline.

Model response

The dashboard refreshed today, but that table is current only through Monday. I'll show the source's data cutoff separately from the dashboard refresh time.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. B - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. A - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. A refreshed dashboard contains Monday's source data - Fictional data-quality update using the lesson case: the dashboard refreshed today, but one source table contains data only through Monday.
2. A successful pipeline with a missing region - Fictional reporting handoff: a pipeline run succeeded, but its input manifest contains files from three of four expected regions.

3. Corrected records have not reached the report - Fictional data-quality case: duplicate source records were corrected, but the dashboard has not rerun since that correction.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A late file has arrived but failed checks

A fictional missing source file has arrived, but its row-count check failed and the reason is unknown. It has not been included in the report. Explain completed receipt, pending validation, and the effect on completeness.

Role A: Data engineer: report the file's actual processing status.

Role B: Business owner: ask whether arrival alone means the dashboard is complete.

Possible opening: The file arrived, but it has not passed validation or entered the report yet.

Success checks

- Separate receipt from validated inclusion.
- Do not invent the reason for the failed check.
- Agree an owner update before changing the completeness claim.

Add a complication: The business owner asks to remove the missing-data notice immediately.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Dashboards and Executive Reporting

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A KPI card shows a monthly total without its target, comparison period, or definition. The reader cannot interpret whether the result is favorable.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: dashboard, KPI, threshold, drill-down.

Model response

The total needs context. I'll add the definition, reporting period, and relevant comparison so the reader can understand what changed and whether action is needed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. A monthly total without an interpretation frame - Fictional dashboard review using the lesson case: a KPI card has a monthly total but no target, comparison period, or definition.
2. A target is not an alert threshold - Fictional service dashboard: an agreed monthly target exists, but the team has not defined an operational alert threshold.

3. A total can conceal where a service problem occurs - Fictional service report: an overall delay measure is available, but regional breakdowns have not been reviewed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The arrow has no comparison label

A fictional KPI card shows 420 and an upward arrow. The comparison period and whether higher is favorable are unspecified. Discuss which labels are needed before the reader can interpret the arrow.

Role A: Dashboard analyst: explain the missing comparison basis.

Role B: Executive reader: ask what the arrow can and cannot mean.

Possible opening: The upward arrow needs a comparison period and metric context before we can call the change favorable.

Success checks

- Do not infer a period or desired direction.
- Distinguish movement from favorable performance.
- Request the metric owner's interpretation basis.

Add a complication: The reader asks to keep the arrow green because upward usually feels positive.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Causation, Correlation, and Caveats

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

Customers who attend training renew more often. Attendance was voluntary, and the groups may differ in motivation.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: correlation, causation, confounder, selection bias.

Model response

Training attendance is associated with renewal in this dataset. That does not establish causation; the groups may differ in other ways. I'll state the finding with that limitation.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. Training attendance and renewal are associated - Fictional analysis discussion using the lesson case: training attendees renew more often, but attendance is voluntary and motivation may differ.
2. Service time fell after two operational changes - Fictional operations analysis: average service time fell after both a staffing change and a new intake form; no separate effects were estimated.

3. A survey describes respondents, not every customer - Fictional survey review: satisfied customers responded more often in a voluntary follow-up; nonrespondents' experiences are unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Adopting teams currently deliver more tasks

In a fictional company, teams that voluntarily adopted a planning tool deliver more tasks. Their performance before adoption has not been compared. Discuss the association and possible selection differences without declaring a tool effect.

Role A: Analytics lead: identify the missing baseline and causal limitation.

Role B: Program sponsor: ask what the current pattern can support.

Possible opening: Adopting teams deliver more tasks, but we haven't compared their performance before adoption.

Success checks

- State the observed association.
- Keep prior performance as an unassessed explanation.
- Recommend a bounded evidence check rather than guaranteed extrapolation.

Add a complication: The sponsor asks to multiply the difference across all teams as guaranteed benefit.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

SQL, Models, and Transformation Logic

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A report joins order rows to several payment rows per order. Revenue appears larger after the join.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: SQL, data model, grain, join logic.

Model response

What does one row represent in each table? The join may repeat order values when there are multiple payments. Let's check the grain and aggregation before interpreting the total.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. B - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. A - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Several payment rows multiply order revenue - Fictional SQL review using the lesson case: order rows join to several payment rows per order, and reported revenue increases after the join.
2. A customer changes regions over time - Fictional data-model review: the customer table stores multiple dated region records, and a report joins orders using customer ID alone.

3. A daily snapshot is not a daily addition - Fictional warehouse report: an inventory table contains daily balance snapshots, and a draft report sums them as if they were daily receipts.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | One customer appears in several campaign groups

A fictional customer table joins to campaign membership with multiple rows per customer. The report requests unique customers reached, but the draft counts joined rows. Clarify the unit and join relationship without prescribing an unexplained SQL shortcut.

Role A: BI analyst: ask about membership grain and the desired customer measure.

Role B: Marketing data owner: distinguish campaign memberships from unique people.

Possible opening: Does each joined row represent a customer or a campaign membership for that customer?

Success checks

- Identify the one-to-many relationship.
- Use the intended entity and verified identifier.
- Agree a traceable sample check before changing the calculation.

Add a complication: The owner suggests deleting repeated names, although different customers can share names.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Experiment Readouts and Statistical Thinking

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An experiment estimates a positive effect, but the interval includes values close to no change. The slide presents only the point estimate.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: sample size, effect size, confidence interval, guardrail.

Model response

I'll show the estimated effect and its uncertainty together. The point estimate alone hides the range of values compatible with the analysis and can make the result sound more certain than it is.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. A - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. C - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. The estimate needs its uncertainty interval - Fictional experiment readout using the lesson case: the point estimate is positive, but its interval includes values near no change; the slide omits the interval.

2. A relative lift needs the absolute change - Fictional experiment: conversion rises from 2% to 2.2%; uncertainty analysis and guardrail review are not complete.

3. An unplanned subgroup result needs a caveat - Fictional experiment review: the overall estimate is modest, and an exploratory subgroup shows a larger estimate; the subgroup was selected after examining results.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A larger sample from a different population

A fictional team proposes combining a small customer experiment with a large employee trial to increase sample size. The populations differ, and comparability has not been assessed. Discuss why more observations alone do not settle the interpretation.

Role A: Experiment analyst: explain the population mismatch.

Role B: Decision sponsor: ask whether separate results would be more informative.

Possible opening: Combining the trials increases the count, but we haven't established that employees and customers answer the same research question.

Success checks

- Distinguish precision from population relevance.
- Do not claim a pooled effect is valid before review.
- Agree to assess comparability and report groups transparently.

Add a complication: The sponsor asks to pool them without a caveat because the interval may become narrower.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Data Governance and Privacy

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

An analyst wants customer-level data but has not specified which fields are needed or how long they will be retained.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: data governance, privacy, access control, retention.

Model response

Could you define the analysis purpose, necessary fields, and retention period? That will let the appropriate team review access and privacy requirements before the data is shared.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Which customer fields are actually needed? - Fictional governance request using the lesson case: an analyst requests customer-level data without specifying fields or retention duration.
2. An external collaborator needs a reviewed extract - Fictional analytics collaboration: an external researcher requests transaction-level records; field necessity, authorization, and transfer method are unconfirmed.

3. A temporary extract remains in a shared folder - Fictional data review: an extract created for a completed analysis remains in a shared folder; its authorized retention period is unknown.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A screenshot includes customer identifiers

A fictional analyst wants to show a dashboard screenshot in an external presentation. Customer identifiers are visible, and publication approval has not been checked. Request a reviewed alternative without declaring that simple masking guarantees privacy.

Role A: Data steward: ask what information the presentation needs and who approves sharing.

Role B: Analyst: propose a synthetic or aggregated example for review.

Possible opening: The screenshot includes customer identifiers; could we use a reviewed example that contains only what the presentation needs?

Success checks

- Distinguish reduced exposure from verified approval.
- Request the minimum necessary presentation content.
- Keep external sharing pending the appropriate review.

Add a complication: The analyst says cropping the names alone proves the image is safe.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Insight Storytelling and Recommendations

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A report lists ten findings but no recommended action. The audience has five minutes to decide whether to investigate a service issue.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: insight, recommendation, assumption, next best action.

Model response

I'll lead with the finding relevant to that decision, explain its limitation, and recommend a specific investigation. The other findings can support the discussion without obscuring the request.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Ten findings need one decision-focused recommendation - Separate fictional executive readout: a report lists ten findings. Eight of ten delayed service tickets lack handoff timestamps, preventing a complete timeline reconstruction. The cause of delay and reason for the missing timestamps are unknown. The audience has five minutes to consider an investigation.

2. A queue pattern suggests where to look first - Fictional service analysis: delays are concentrated in the intake queue during the observed week; staffing and demand causes have not been assessed.

3. Recommend a check before replacing a supplier - Fictional delivery analysis: one supplier has a higher recorded late-delivery rate, but requested delivery windows differ across suppliers.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A recommendation depends on an unverified address field

A fictional report recommends contacting customers in one region, but the region field may refer to billing rather than service location. The field definition is unverified. Explain why the next action should begin with clarification.

Role A: Analytics lead: identify the assumption beneath the recommendation.

Role B: Service manager: ask what can be decided before outreach begins.

Possible opening: The outreach recommendation depends on what region means, and that field definition is still unverified.

Success checks

- State the dependency between definition and action.
- Avoid presenting billing location as confirmed service location.
- Recommend an owner-confirmed definition check before outreach.

Add a complication: The manager wants to contact the listed customers first and clarify afterward.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.